Chapter 3

Preparing to Be Assets: Learning to Win

DURING HER ACADEMIC YEARS, KIRAN WAS ALSO SERIOUSLY AND vigorously pursuing competitive tennis. Along with her sister Reeta she had won for the Punjab University the interuniversity women's team title. Besides innumerable state and zonal championships, Kiran won the National Junior Championship in 1966 and the senior national title in 1974. She had bagged the Asian title in 1972. One thing very clear to her was that the world has no time for losers. The right attitude and the right strategies that one needed to be a winner in tennis were the ones for life too. Nothing came easily, and every move had to be planned and worked for. The going was invariably tough and needed the maximum possible hard work and a total determination to achieve what one wanted to. The tennis courts symbolized for Kiran both negative and positive features, such as the qualities of discrimination, misuse of power, sycophancy as also the undiluted admiration for the champion.

The girls had to fight for their rights with respect to not just travel allowances but even the choice of courts. Many a time, during important matches like the semi-finals and the finals, the girls were relegated to the side courts. They had to struggle tenaciously for their right to play on the main courts as befitted the status of the match. Once, during the National Tennis Championships in Calcutta in 1969, the finals were considerably delayed because the girls, Nirupama Mankad-Vasant, Susan Dass, Udaya Kumar, Kiran and others, demanded their right to play on the centre court. The organizers did ultimately relent and the girls' protest for their rightful place in the sun was upheld. Kiran learnt her lessons well, and one of them was that one had to assert oneself for even that which was one's due. Otherwise, one tended to be ignored. Those who have no influential backing have to stay alive to their surroundings and create their own rightful space.

During the interuniversity championships at Bangalore in 1968, Kiran and her sister Reeta took on the local pair of Udaya Kumar, then ranked as India's number 4, and Chandrika in the finals. Kiran won her singles match against Chandrika, but Reeta lost to Udaya Kumar to make the score one all. The visibility had become poor and Reeta, who had a little problem with her vision, requested that the doubles match be resumed the next day. The appeal was turned down and the match was awarded to the Bangalore pair by default. Quite unfazed, the sisters were all fired up to win the both the reverse singles the next day. And they did. Together they gave their Punjab University the coveted interuniversity title the second time in a row.

The Asian Lawn Tennis Championships of 1972 were held in Poona (now Pune). Kiran faced Udaya Kumar in the semifinals. Kiran had won the first set 6-3, and was leading 5-3 in the second set, when the very vociferous crowd led by an antagonistic coach named Akhtar Ali rattled her and she went down 5-7. During the third set the crowd was on its feet and Kiran further slid to 1-3, 15-30. She looked at her father, who glared at her as much as to express his frustration as to say that she had